

Email Auto-Forwarding Prohibition

CUNY Cybersecurity Standards

Standard Owner: CUNY Offices of Cybersecurity and Information Security
Approver: Eusebio Formoso, Vice Chancellor for Information Technology and University CIO
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1.0 Purpose

This standard describes the University’s prohibition on automatically forwarding (resending) email from a CUNY email service to a non-CUNY email service and provides alternative solutions. Email auto-forwarding is typically used to avoid separately accessing multiple email accounts (e.g., personal and University-related). Its use, however, raises concerns regarding security, privacy and reliability, and risks potential legal and public institution governance implications. Email auto-forwarding can also be technically problematic.

2.0 Audience

Any holder of an assigned a University email address, including students, faculty, staff, and affiliates of CUNY.

3.0 Scope

To prevent the unauthorized or inadvertent disclosure of sensitive University information from all University email addresses ending in cuny.edu.

4.0 Definitions

Affiliate

Any organization associated with the University that uses University resources such as email to carry out its business functions. This applies to all third-party vendors under a contractual agreement.

Confidential Data

Data and information for which unauthorized disclosure, alteration or destruction could result in a significant level of risk to the University. See the CUNY Data Classification Standard for a comprehensive confidential data description as well as examples.

Electronic Discovery (eDiscovery)

The process used in legal proceedings to collect, review, and exchange electronically stored information, such as email and file attachments, for use as evidence.

Freedom of Information Law (FOIL)

New York State's Freedom of Information Law provides the right to access records that reflect government decisions and policies that affect New York residents. CUNY email may be subject to FOIL requests.

Non-Public University Information (NPUI)

Non-public University information was an earlier data classification standard that has been superseded by the more-specific CUNY Confidential and CUNY Sensitive data classifications defined in the CUNY Data Classification Standard.

Sensitive Data

Data and information for which unauthorized disclosure, alteration or destruction could result in a moderate to low level of risk to the University. See the CUNY Data Classification Standard for a comprehensive sensitive data description as well as examples.

Unauthorized Disclosure

The release of information to individuals or entities without proper authorization, potentially leading to data breaches and privacy issues.

5.0 Resources

The following individuals and group are responsible for developing and managing this standard:

- University Chief Cybersecurity Risk Officer
- University Chief Information Security Officer
- Computing and Information Services offices of Cybersecurity and Information Security

- Computing and Information Services Microsoft Applications, Infrastructure and Messaging Operations team

6.0 Standard Statements

A cuny.edu (that is, CUNY provided) email account should be used to issue and receive CUNY-related email communications. Email sent to a CUNY email address mailbox shall not be forwarded through an automated means to a non-CUNY destination email address.

University email systems must be configured to prevent or disallow auto-forwarding where technically feasible.

6.1 Alternative to Email Auto-Forwarding

CUNY email can be accessed using mobile devices with no use of auto-forwarding required. Mobile devices, desktop email applications, etc., support concurrent access to multiple email accounts by combining email from separate accounts into a consolidated view. In this way, the need to auto-forward email from one account to another is conveniently avoided.

For email setup and support information, contact the campus IT department.

6.2 Manually Forwarding CUNY Email

Selected email may be manually forwarded by a CUNY user to a non-CUNY destination when such forwarding:

- a. will not result in an inappropriate disclosure of CUNY Sensitive or Confidential Data (formerly called “non-public University information” or NPUI)
- b. does not also automatically delete the email from the CUNY mail server
- c. complies with the requirements of the CUNY Policy on Acceptable Use of Digital Assets and Resources

6.3 Potential Issues Posed by Auto-forwarding Email

Auto-forwarding CUNY email to non-CUNY email addresses introduces potential issues and risks like the following:

Unauthorized Disclosure Risks:

Auto-forwarding increases the risk of inappropriate disclosure of CUNY Confidential or Sensitive information, including personally identifiable information (PII), such as Social Security numbers.

While email is generally not an appropriate method for transmitting unencrypted confidential or sensitive information, the risk is increased when such data leaves CUNY’s secure systems.

Compliance Challenges:

Auto-forwarding complicates adherence to legal requirements, such as the New York State Freedom of Information Law (FOIL) and e-Discovery processes, making it harder to locate and retrieve relevant emails. It may also expose personal email accounts to legal disclosure.

Email Server Blockages:

External email providers may block CUNY email or servers if excessive spam is auto-forwarded, potentially leading to widespread and prolonged communication disruptions across the University.

Third-Party Terms of Service Risks:

Many non-CUNY email providers impose terms of service that allow them to collect, read, use, distribute, or even claim ownership of emails sent to their systems. This compromises data privacy and security.

Delivery Issues:

Senders may not receive non-delivery receipts ("bounce back" notifications) if emails fail to deliver to an auto-forwarded address, leaving critical messages undetected.

Important CUNY emails may experience delays or fail to be delivered entirely, disrupting communication.

Troubleshooting and Diagnostic Challenges:

CUNY IT support may face increased difficulty in diagnosing and resolving delivery issues when dealing with non-CUNY email providers.

Interference with Anti-Spam Measures:

Auto-forwarding can interfere with spam prevention protocols, such as Sender Policy Framework (SPF), resulting in increased email filtering complexities.

7.0 Related Standards, Guidelines, Procedures and Best Practices

- [CUNY Data Classification Standard](#)
- [CUNY Service Provider Standard](#)
- SP 800-122: [Guide to Protecting the Confidentiality of Personally Identifiable Information \(PII\)](#)

8.0 Applicable Policies, Rules, Laws and Regulations

- [CUNY Acceptable Use of Digital Assets and Resources Policy](#)
- [CUNY Records Retention Schedule](#)
- [Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act \(FERPA\)](#)
- [New York Freedom of Information Law](#)

9.0 Approvals

This policy was approved by the University officer listed below and is now in force:

Approved on January 24, 2025, by Eusebio Formoso, Vice Chancellor for Information Technology and University CIO

10.0 Revision History

Version	Change	Author	Date of Change
1	First publication of Email Auto-Forwarding Information Security Procedure	University Chief Information Security Officer	12/1/2015
2	Republished as a CUNY Cybersecurity Standard with new format, minor edits, and updated hyperlinks	CUNY Offices of Cybersecurity and Information Security	1/24/2025